

Science Students' Association Council Meeting

Date: 2026-09-23

Location: Human Ecology 207

Chaired By: Nick Sarte, Executive Assistant

Meeting type: Regular



Attendance

Position	Name	Attendance
President	Noah Crossman	Present
Vice President	Caleb Pereira	Present
Chairperson	Reyna Torres	Absent with regrets
Secretary	Jason Hong	Present
Senator	Yashsavi Negi	Absent with regrets
Senator	Hargun Uppal	Present
Senator	Kushal Joshi	Present
UMSU Director	Danylo Kruk	Present
Director of Student Advocacy	Roopak Brar	Present
International Representative	Gurminder Singh	Absent with regrets
Women's Representative	Zaina Abazid	Present
First Years' Representative	Vacant	Position vacant
Racialized Representative	Vacant	Position vacant
Black Students' Representative	Seun Fatunmbi	Present
2SLGBTQIA+ Representative	Alice Miranda Gislason	Present
Accessibility Representative	Victoria Vong	Present
Indigenous Representative	April Quill	Present
Treasurer	Anshika Sharma	Present
Lounge Programmer	Sean Delaney	Present
Executive Assistant	Nick Sarte	Present
External Partnerships Programmer	Hamza Haque	Present
Director of Communications	Yeeun Ryu	Absent with regrets
Communications Programmer (Marketing)	Vincenzina Conia	Present
Communications Programmer (Marketing)	Imrose Dhaliwal	Present
Communications Programmer (Media)	Alix Ganetsky	Present
Communications Programmer (Productions)	Hashmeen Kaur	Present
Director of Special Events	Quinn Derksen	Present
Special Events Programmer (Social)	Jayden Gupta	Present
Special Events Programmer (Social)	Zenah Large	Present
Special Events Programmer (Research)	Fatin Shadab Talukder	Absent with regrets
Special Events Programmer (Research)	Benjamin Lehman	Present

Position	Name	Attendance
Director of Student Services	Ian Ogwen	Present
Student Services Programmer (Academics)	Erica Wong	Present
Student Services Programmer (Academics)	Mary Lozano	Present
Student Services Programmer (Operations)	Harsh Kumar	Present
Student Services Programmer (Operations)	Matthew Gray	Absent with regrets
Student Services Programmer (Outreach)	Kay Durojaiye	Present

Regrets and Proxies

Elected Councillors

- Yashsavi Negi; Senator.
 - Proxy: Nick Sarte; Executive Assistant.
- Gurminder Singh; International Representative
 - Proxy: Zenah Large; Special Events Programmer (Social)

Appointed Councillors

- Fatin Shadab Talukder; Special Events Programmer (Research)
- Matthew Gray; Student Services Programmer (Operations)
- Yeeun Ryu; Director of Communications

Guests

- Heaven Kaur; President of UMSU
- Grace Elendu; Vice President of University Affairs of UMSU

Minutes

Call to Order

Chairperson Nick Sarte called the meeting to order at 6:04 p.m.

Approval of Agenda

A motion to approve the agenda was moved by Vice President Caleb Pereira and seconded by Director of Student Advocacy Roopak Brar. The agenda was approved as written.

Treaty Land Acknowledgement

Chairperson Sarte read the treaty land acknowledgement of the SSA.

Approval of Previous Meeting Minutes

A motion to approve the previous meeting's minutes was moved by Vice President Pereira and seconded by Brar. The meeting minutes were approved as written.

Reports of Councillors

President and Vice President

- President Noah Crossman and Vice President Pereira gave a summation of the Report of the President and Vice President.
- **Questions:**
 - President Crossman asked whether having deans of the Faculty of Science present at the SSA Town Hall, as they have in previous Town Halls, is beneficial or a hindrance. If a hindrance, President Crossman or Vice President Pereira may give updates on behalf of the deans.
 - Senator Joshi and Director of Student Advocacy Brar spoke in favour of having the deans present, as they are not easy to access for students-at-large.
 - 2SLGBTQIA+ Representative Gislason asked how students may nominate themselves as candidates at the upcoming General Assembly to fill the vacant First Years' Representative and Racialized Representative positions.
 - Vice President Pereira stated that candidates may simply nominate themselves at the General Assembly as long as they self-identify with the group they are running to represent.
 - Secretary Hong asked whether voting for the Community Representatives at the General Assembly will be restricted to those who self-identify with the groups the Community Representatives will represent.
 - Pereira stated that all students will count toward quorum for the General Assembly. However, voters will be asked only to vote in the elections in which they self-identify for the respective Community Representative group.
 - Senator Uppal asked about the current situation regarding expansion of the SSA Lounge courtyard.
 - President Crossman stated that the courtyard is currently unfinished due to a lack of funds during a previous year. If the previous landscaping architects are still on leave, then the SSA could consider hiring an external architect. The SSA now has the funds to complete an expansion, but Councillors noted that few people use the courtyard.
 - Lounge Programmer Delaney stated that students have been using the undeveloped section of the courtyard to play badminton and frisbee, expressing uncertainty about developing the area.
 - Communications Programmer (Productions) Kaur asked about how the proposal to use the referendum fund to create a Neuroscience program (an idea from the 2025-26 academic year) would work.
 - Crossman stated that 2025-26 SSA President Jasmine Groisman had spoken to the Department of Biological Sciences. The program would exist as its own degree path under Biological Sciences, and the primary use of funding would be to pay the salaries of instructors.
 - Kaur asked if the referendum fund could be used to fund a Pre-Optometry program at the university, stating that the program would not require new instructors, but only a new stream.
 - Crossman stated that this can be discussed with the Associate Dean of Programs.
 - Student Services Programmer (Outreach) Durojaiye asked if the referendum fund could be used to fund additional sections in courses that currently struggle with long waitlists.
 - Crossman stated that he is unsure how talks would go, but said that it is a conversation he can have with the Associate Dean of Programs.

Treasurer

- Treasurer Sharma gave a summation of the Report of the Treasurer.
- Sharma presented the 2026-27 SSA Budget.
- **Motion for the Approval of the 2026-27 SSA Budget:** A motion to approve the SSA's budget for the academic year was moved by Kushal Joshi and seconded by Zaina Abazid. The motion was carried without opposition.
- **Comments:**

- Director of Student Advocacy Brar stated that the open bar and cheap ticket prices present at the 2025-26 SSA Gala were positive for student engagement, expressing concern about the cut to the Gala's alcohol budget.
- President Crossman requested a round of applause for Sharma's work on preparing the SSA budget.
- UMSU Director Kruk stated that during the 2025-26 academic year, then SSA President Jasmine Groisman requested Kruk offset the costs of awards given at the 2025-26 SSA Gala. He stated that he was in contact with the head of awards of the Faculty of Science, who would circle back the following year. Kruk stated he will forward his conversation to the Special Events Team or External Partnerships Programmer.
 - Senator Joshi stated that with the funds allocated to awards during the Gala, further savings may be made through a reduction of the awards budget.
 - Crossman stated that the budget reduction was to reduce alcohol, not cut the Gala itself.
 - Crossman also noted that the reduction in funds will likely be offset by increased funds from ticket sales and an increased focus on securing sponsors.
- Director of Special Events Derksen expressed concern over reductions in the SSA Gala's budget, stating that it is uncertain that revenue from ticket sales will increase.
 - Crossman stated that the budget does not comprise all of the SSA's funds. Not all of the SSA's savings have been allocated, but the funds can be drawn on if necessary.
 - Sharma stated that there may be extra funds in the budget over time from allocations that go unspent.
 - Vice President Pereira stated that if any team has concerns over a lack of funding, the SSA will be receptive, and that no team should be stressed about the amount of funds they have been given.
- **Questions:**
 - Director of Student Services Ogwenko asked about the mechanics of working with the Princeton Review.
 - Kruk stated that in a previous year the Princeton Review gave away materials for free and provided Council members with a discount on materials.

UMSU Director [†]

Senators [†]

Director of Student Advocacy [†]

Indigenous Representative

- Indigenous Representative Quill provided a summation of the Report of the Indigenous Representative.

International Representative [†]

Accessibility Representative

- Accessibility Representative Vong gave a summation of the Report of the Accessibility Representative.
- **Comments:**
 - President Crossman thanked Vong for her work on the SSA Discord.
 - Crossman encouraged Councillors to post the SSA's Instagram announcements on the SSA Discord. Councillors who are interested in assisting in the SSA Discord are encouraged to contact Crossman.

2SLGBTQIA+ Representative †

Women's Representative †

First Years' Representative †

Racialized Representative †

Black Students' Representative †

Communications

- In Director of Communications Ryu's absence, Communications Programmer (Media) Ganetsky provided a summation of the Report of the Communications Team.

Student Services

- Director of Student Services Ogwen, Student Services Programmer (Academics) Wong, and Student Services Programmer (Academics) Lozano provided a summation of the Report of the Student Services Team.
- **Orientation Ice Cream Reimbursement Motion:** A motion to reimburse \$143.66 in ice cream purchased for orientation events was moved by Danylo Kruk and seconded by Hargun Uppal. The motion was carried without opposition.

Special Events

- Director of Special Events Derksen provided a summation of the Report of the Special Events Team.
- **Team Bonding Pizza Reimbursement Motion:** A motion to reimburse Vice President Pereira for \$138.24 in pizzas purchased for SSA team bonding was moved by Noah Crossman and seconded by April Quill. The motion was carried with one opposition vote from Danylo Kruk.
- **LabTREK Reimbursement Motion:** A motion to reimburse Vice President Pereira for \$448.25 in pizzas purchased for LabTREK was moved by Danylo Kruk and seconded by Noah Crossman. The motion was carried with one opposition vote from Danylo Kruk, who moved the motion.
- **Breakfast and Gratuities Reimbursement Motion:** A motion to reimburse Derksen for \$237.39 for spending on breakfast, gratuities, drinks, and snacks was moved by Caleb Pereira and seconded by Noah Crossman. The motion was carried without opposition.
- **Comments:**
 - President Crossman thanked the Special Events team for their work on LabTREK.
- **Questions:**
 - Crossman asked if the Special Events team had any plans aside from the planned event for Orange Shirt Day.
 - Derksen stated that a member of the Physical Education Recreational Kinesiology Student Council (PERKS) wanted to collaborate to hold a running event. Updates on this potential event will be given at a subsequent meeting.

Lounge Programmer

- Lounge Programmer Delaney provided a summation of the Report of the Lounge Programmer.

Reports of Committees

Executive Committee

- Vice President Pereira provided a summation of the Report of the Executive Committee, in lieu of Executive Assistant Sarte who was serving as the Chairperson of the meeting.
- **Comments:**
 - Sarte reminded Councillors that the deadline to join the Board of Science Groups (BOSG) is approaching soon (September 30, 11:59 p.m.). Councillors were encouraged to spread this reminder.

- **Questions:**

- Senator Joshi asked if the deadline to apply to the BOSG would be extended if a group was awaiting full recognition by UMSU, or if a group was awaiting UMSU approval for constitutional amendments required to join the BOSG. It was noted that the process to amend a club constitution is often slow to complete.
- Sarte stated that if a group has been pre-approved by UMSU and the group's executives have completed the required Sexual Violence Prevention Workshop for approval, they can contact him and explain the group's situation, and contact him subsequently upon obtaining full recognition.
- With regard to the constitutional amendments, Sarte stated that he will contact all groups expected to join the BOSG, working with groups on a case-by-case basis.

Selections Committee †

Bylaws Committee †

Miscellaneous

- Following the Report of the President and Vice President, UMSU President Heaven Kaur and UMSU Vice President of University Affairs Grace Elendu visited the SSA Council meeting.
- **Guest Speaking Motion:** A motion to allow Kaur and Elendu to speak was moved by President Crossman and seconded by Senator Joshi. The motion was carried without opposition.
- UMSU President Kaur reminded Councillors of UMSU's planned protest at the Manitoba Legislative Building.
- Elendu reminded Councillors of UMSU's Ask Admin event.
- **Questions:**
 - Senator Joshi asked whether there is anything the SSA could help with in regards to the events.
 - UMSU President Kaur responded, stating that it would be helpful to advertise the event to students.
- **Discussion:**
 - UMSU Director Kruk mentioned that some Councillors had questions regarding the resignation of the Vice President of External Affairs and Vice President of Finance and Operations of UMSU.
 - Elendu stated that the UMSU Executive Committee would prefer that a by-election not be held. She stated the period between May, when the elected executives take office, and August, is a critical period for executives to become effective in their roles. Elendu stated that if a by-election were held in October, the elected candidates would take office in November and reach optimal performance in March before their term ends in May.
 - Treasurer Sharma and Director of Student Advocacy Brar expressed concern about potential delays for things like email communications or approval from UMSU.
 - UMSU President Kaur stated that there will be no additional delays to responses. Kaur stated that emails directed to the inboxes of the Vice President of External Affairs and Vice President of Finance and Operations will be directed to her inbox, stating that emails should be responded to on the same day or the day after.
 - UMSU President Kaur stated that an additional person will be hired by the end of October to assist in the portfolio of UMSU Services Coordinator Mathew Chomyn to prevent delays.
 - Vice President Pereira asked whether the division of executive portfolios will be transparently communicated if a by-election is not held.
 - Elendu stated that the current proposal for dividing the roles of the resigned executives among the remaining executives is in a Board of Directors motion that is publicly available. Elendu stated that the division of roles was deliberated upon extensively by the remaining executives.
 - UMSU President Kaur stated that the division of roles is not ideal, but stated that she believed it was the best option given the circumstances.
 - Pereira expressed concern about the proposal to not hold a by-election to fill the vacated executive positions, stating that by having the remaining UMSU executives take over the portfolios of the

two executives who resigned, the mandate of the remaining executives may be diluted. Pereira expressed concern delays will occur if roles are divided as the semester progresses and executives become more occupied with coursework.

- Elendu stated that if a by-election is not held, the salaries of the resigned executives would be allocated in a motion submitted to the UMSU Board of Directors. Elendu noted that in the previous year, the salaries of resigned executives were allocated to the University of Manitoba Food Bank.

New Business

- Treasurer Sharma requested that when filling out the SSA Councillor reimbursement form, Councillors match the budget category on the form with the same ballot allocation as the newly approved SSA budget.
- Treasurer Sharma stated that the SSA received the 30% advance payment from UMSU.
- **Council Meeting Pizza Motion:** A motion to reimburse the cost of \$167.83 in pizza purchased for the present Council meeting was moved by Kushal Joshi and seconded by Seun Fatunmbi. The motion was carried without opposition.
- President Crossman thanked Executive Assistant Sarte for chairing the meeting.
- Vice President Pereira thanked Councillors for their work.

Adjournment

A motion to adjourn the meeting was moved by Danylo Kruk and seconded by Noah Crossman. The motion was adopted without objection and the meeting was adjourned at 8:08 p.m.

Motions

All motions moved are shown below.

Motion: Approval of the 2026-27 SSA Budget

Category: Treasurer's Report

Approve the 2026-27 SSA Budget.

Moved by: Kushal Joshi

Seconded by: Zaina Abazid

Status: Passed

Motion: Orientation Ice Cream Reimbursement

Category: Student Services Report

Reimburse \$143.66 in ice cream purchased for orientation events.

Moved by: Danylo Kruk

Seconded by: Hargun Uppal

Status: Passed

Motion: Team Bonding Pizza Reimbursement

Category: Special Events Report

Reimburse \$138.24 in pizza purchased for SSA team bonding.

Moved by: Noah Crossman

Seconded by: April Quill

Status: Passed

Motion: LabTREK Reimbursement

Category: Special Events Report

Reimburse \$448.25 in food purchased for LabTREK.

Moved by: Danylo Kruk

Seconded by: Noah Crossman

Status: Passed

Motion: Breakfast and Gratuities Reimbursement

Category: Special Events Report

Reimburse \$237.39 in breakfast, gratuities, drinks, and snacks.

Moved by: Caleb Pereira

Seconded by: Noah Crossman

Status: Passed

Motion: Guest Speaking Motion*Category: Miscellaneous*

Grant guest speaking time to UMSU President Heaven Kaur and UMSU Vice President of University Affairs Grace Elendu.

Moved by: Noah Crossman**Seconded by:** Kushal Joshi**Status:** Passed**Motion: Council Meeting Pizza***Category: New Business*

Reimburse \$167.83 in pizza purchased for the present Council meeting.

Moved by: Kushal Joshi**Seconded by:** Seun Fatunmbi**Status:** Passed